

Selective Attention

What is it?

Focusing on what matters while filtering out distractions. People zoom into the most relevant detail and ignore the rest.

History

Selective attention was studied heavily in cognitive psychology in the late 1950s, especially through Donald Broadbent's attention research model (1958).

The Psychology Behind It

The brain can't process everything around it equally, so it prioritizes what aligns with the current goal or task. This is why users will ignore anything that doesn't support their immediate intention inside a product — even if those elements are visible on screen.

Why It Matters

- Helps users focus on specific actions
- Can cause ad blindness
- Users may miss important changes or updates

How to Apply It

- Clear, focused messaging
- Visually highlight key actions (contrast, CTA colour, size)
- Use visual cues like icons or subtle motion
- Use novelty strategically for important moments (pop-ups, micro animations)

Theory in Action

Google Maps shows only what matters for the moment: route, ETA, and traffic, hiding unnecessary noise.

Fast-food chains use simplified digital menu screens while people wait, making focus easier and faster.

Final Thought

Selective attention helps users move with purpose — but it also means anything unimportant will be ignored instantly. Good UX guides focus to the right thing at the right time, without overwhelming the screen.

